



its supporters such as Niall Ferguson would have us believe; or did it irrevocably destroy millennia-old trading networks?

Did it bring democracy to a part of the world inured to despotism and tyranny; or did it remove political freedom of expression from lands with long traditions of debate and public expression of dissent, as argued by Amartya Sen? Did the British Empire bring in constitutional guarantees of the freedom of the individual; or promote slavery, exploitation, indentured labour and forced migration? Did the British bring just governance

LANGUAGE EDGE: In several areas, English-speaking India has an advantage over China



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and irrigate the deserts, or did they plunder natural resources, drive a succession of species to extinction and preside over a succession of famines which left many million dead while surplus grain was being shipped to Britain?

Certainly, the British introduced the important innovations of democracy and the rule of law, along with the railways. They also brought, in the Indian Civil Service (or ICS), a tradition of uncorrupt and impartial administration run by a meritocratic bureaucracy. It is also true that the English language has been crucial to India's modern success, setting Indian eyes looking westwards to the rising power of Britain and later America, and away from the declining Islamo-Persianate culture of Central and Western Asia. In the days that followed the fall of the Mughals after 1857, this turning away from the old cultural moorings and the reorientation of India towards the West caused heart break to the old North Indian Urdu and Persian-speaking elites. As the poet and critic Azad wrote: "The glory of the winners' ascendant fortune gives everything of theirs—even their dress, their gait,

their conversation—a radiance that makes them desirable. And people do not merely adopt them, but they are proud to adopt them." Yet it was the depth of that reorientation and adoption, and the ease with which Indians can now cross the globe and work in either Britain or America, that today has given the country's Anglicised elite such an easy access to the jobs and opportunities of the Western economy, and gives them such an advantage in so many fields over their only real rivals, the Chinese.

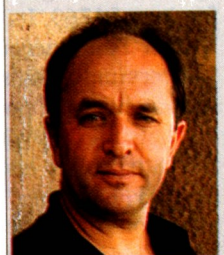
Nevertheless, for all this, the British should keep their nostalgia over the achievements of the

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Raj within firm boundaries. Many styles of architecture and art, forms of writing and ways of living were pushed into extinction in the course of the Colonial period, albeit assisted by the eagerness of so many Brown Sahibs to embrace Western ways of living. Even decades after Independence, India remained the epitome of a Third World nation, best known in the West through well-meant but humiliating Oxfam adverts of famished children: donate £2 and give Sita the gift of sight...

Today, however, we are back to a world that Strabo would immediately recognise. India is again famous not for deprivation but for its trading opportunities and its pockets of great wealth, as well as the brilliance of its writers (both of software and literature); for its fine food and beautiful women; for its growing political importance. As in the days of the Great Mughal, barely a week goes by without some diplomatic delegation arriving in Delhi, cap in hand, begging for trading privileges just as once William Hawkins and Sir Thomas Roe bowed before the *musnud* of Jahangir.

Today, only 60 years after the last British troops marched through the Gateway of India on the 16th of August 1947 to their waiting P&O steamers, we *firangis* are no longer the solar topee-wearing *burra* sahibs, but clients for the goods and services of Mother India—and aspirants for her favours.



William Dalrymple's new book, *The Last Mughal: The Fall of a Dynasty, Delhi 1857*, published by Penguin India, has just been awarded the Duff Cooper Prize for History.